

# Beaver County Times

Tuesday July 27, 2010

## Phillips Power Station building's fate undecided

By: Bob Bauder  
Beaver County Times

**SOUTH HEIGHTS** — Duquesne Light Co. is in the final stages of dismantling its portion of the long-shuttered Phillips Power Station straddling Beaver and Allegheny counties, but the status of the main plant building remains in question.

Duquesne Light spokesman Joseph Vallarian said the company has eliminated an electrical substation in South Heights near the intersection of Routes 51 and 151.

In recent weeks, workers have torn down towers that once carried transmission lines and removed generators and other electrical equipment from the facility bordering Route 51.

The company sold Phillips, which has been closed since the 1990s, to Orion Power MidWest LP in 2000, but retained the substation. Most of the plant property, totaling about 50 acres and including the large power generating building, is in Crescent Township and has changed hands several times over the past decade.

Vallarian said Duquesne Light decided to eliminate the substation because of outdated equipment. He said the company has no plans for the eight-acre property.

What will become of the remainder of the plant is another issue.

The property is now owned by Houston-based RRI Energy Inc. Crescent Township Manager Patience Eckhardt said she has received telephone queries about the property in recent weeks from attorneys and appraisers.

"Rumor is that it's being sold, but all that is right now is rumor. We have no confirmation," Eckhardt said.

An RRI spokeswoman said in an e-mail that the property has not sold, but she did not respond to additional questions or an interview request. RRI in April announced a \$1.6 billion merger with Mirant Corp. and the formation of a new power-generating company to be known as GenOn Energy and based in Houston. The merger is expected to be completed by year's end.

Eckhardt said the company has been equally unresponsive to township inquiries.

She described the plant as a frequent irritation for township police, who have responded to numerous complaints about metal theft there.

"We would love to see something develop there, but as of right now we don't know of anything," Eckhardt said.

Christened the Frank E. Phillips Power Station after a former president of Duquesne Light at its dedication in January 1943, the coal-fired facility was a landmark and later an eyesore at the Beaver-Allegheny county border.

It was built at an estimated cost of \$8 million to increase Duquesne Light's electrical generating capacity for

Beaver County Times: Phillips Power Station building's fate undecided

local industry that was operating at monumental levels during World War II.

The Times reported in the late 1940s that the plant had capacity to power the entire Pittsburgh region.

By the 1990s, however, industry had all but disappeared from the area, and Duquesne Light decided to idle the plant. Several attempts to restart it over the years have been unsuccessful.